EMERGENCY NILE BASIN CONTACT GROUP

Drought, the Blue Nile Dams, and the Prevention of Interstate War

Delegate Background Guide and Position Sheet • Freeze date 12 November 2026, 09:00 EAT • Nairobi

Field	Detail
Committee	Emergency contact group convened by the African Union with United Nations support. Not a standing body — it exists to prevent a war.
Format	Crisis committee. Directives, national leverage, and live updates from the dais.
Delegations	25 States; one vote each; no veto in this room. Substantive measures pass by simple majority; the final instrument aims for consensus.
Not represented	Egypt and Ethiopia. Neither attends. Both act continuously outside this room and respond to what the committee does.

1. Mandate and Authority

This group convenes in Nairobi as the African Union, with United Nations support and the participation of Nile Basin riparian states, African Union members, Gulf and Near East powers, the permanent members of the Security Council, and the principal donors to basin institutions. It is not the African Union Peace and Security Council, not the UN Security Council, and not the Nile Basin Commission. It has no treaty authority over anybody. The group can offer money, technical capacity, monitoring, guarantees, recognition and political cover, and it can withhold the same things. It cannot order a State to stop filling a reservoir or to demobilise an army. Delegations that spend the first session drafting binding language for two governments that are not in the room will accomplish nothing.

The immediate objective is to prevent the use of force. The medium objective is a numbers agreement — how much Ethiopia may take, what minimum it must pass downstream, what both figures become in a drought, and who verifies them. That is the only thing in this dispute that has ever come close to agreement. The long objective, a permanent basin framework acceptable upstream and downstream, has defeated every process since 1999 and will not be solved here.

2. Membership and Procedure

Category	Delegations
Nile Basin riparian States	Sudan, South Sudan, Uganda, Kenya, Tanzania, Rwanda, Burundi, DR Congo, Eritrea
African Union States	Nigeria, South Africa, Somalia, Djibouti
Gulf and Near East	Saudi Arabia, United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Turkey
Permanent Members of the Security Council	United States, China, Russian Federation, France, United Kingdom
Donors and technical partners	Italy, Germany, Norway

- Egypt and Ethiopia are not members and do not attend. Both governments are run by the dais, both are acting continuously while the committee sits, and both will respond to what it does. Delegations reach them by directive, not by debate.

- Six delegations in this room have ratified the Cooperative Framework Agreement that entered into force in October 2024 — Uganda, Rwanda, Tanzania, Burundi, South Sudan and, outside this room, Ethiopia. Sudan rejects it. That split runs through every legal question the committee will touch on, and ewt is not a proxy for the Egypt–Ethiopia dispute: it is older and wider than that.
- Delegates may direct the instruments listed under Leverage in their position entry through private directives; joint directives require every contributing delegation's sponsorship; public statements and the final instrument require a vote. The dais issues updates on its own schedule and will not wait for debate to finish — both parties are acting continuously, and the water level moves whether or not anyone has yielded the floor.

3. Background and Committee Agenda

3.1 The river and the law

Eleven States share the Nile basin. Ethiopia's highlands generate roughly 85 per cent of the water, arriving through the Blue Nile, the Atbara cataract and the Sobat cataract, while Egypt contributes essentially none of it, has historically consumed the most, and depends on the river almost totally. Egyptian per capita availability of water is far below the 1,000 cubic metre scarcity threshold and still falling; about 85 per cent of it goes to agriculture.

The legal architecture is contested at its foundation. A 1929 exchange of notes concluded by Britain (as a colonial power) gave Egypt rights over upstream works; a 1959 agreement between Egypt and Sudan divided the entire measured flow between them — 55.5 billion cubic metres to Egypt, 18.5 to Sudan — and allocated nothing to Ethiopia or to any other riparian state, none of whom were party to it. Upstream States have never accepted either instrument. In 2010 seven of them opened the Cooperative Framework Agreement, built on equitable and reasonable utilisation rather than historic rights; it was entered into force in October 2024 on South Sudan's ratification and established a Nile Basin Commission. Egypt and Sudan rejected it and did not sign.

3.2 The dams

Ethiopia began the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Hydroelectric Dam in 2011, financed it domestically at close to five billion dollars, filled it in stages from 2020, and inaugurated it on 9 September 2025 at roughly 5,150 megawatts of electricity. Egypt objected throughout, raised it at the Security Council that month, and did not stop it. A 2015 Declaration of Principles committed all three parties to agree on filling and operating rules; those talks collapsed in December 2023.

Crucially, the GERD is a hydropower dam. Water passing its turbines continues downstream, so once filling ends it changes when Egypt receives water, not how much. Egypt objected to the filling schedule and to losing control, not to a permanent loss of volume. In March 2026 Ethiopia announced three further Blue Nile hydropower projects — Karadobi, Mandaya and Beko Abo — and Cairo's policy shifted accordingly, from preventing construction to demanding a say in how dams are designed, filled and operated. That was the dispute as it stood in the spring.

3.3 Storage is not hydropower

A hydropower reservoir borrows water; a storage reservoir supplying irrigation consumes it. Water impounded for a command area is applied to fields, transpired by crops and evaporated off the surface, and what returns is a fraction of what was taken. The loss is permanent and recurs every year the scheme operates. Egypt and Sudan have understood for decades that large-scale Ethiopian irrigation abstraction, not hydropower, is what would actually reduce the volume reaching them.

This changes the legal argument. Against a hydropower dam Egypt argued about schedules and could be offered a water filling timetable, dictating how much water is used. Against consumptive abstraction Egypt argues for

Ethiopia to not take significant amounts of water, every cubic metre Ethiopia keeps is one Egypt never gets. Ethiopia answers with equitable and reasonable utilisation: it supplies most of the river, irrigates a fraction of what Egypt does, and asks why the State contributing nothing to the flow holds a permanent claim to almost all of it. With a multi-year drought this dispute becomes about who absorbs a shortfall of water that cannot be shared without someone losing.

4. The November 2026 Emergency

The 2026 current season was the third consecutive one to fail across the Ethiopian highlands. Blue Nile flow has run far below the long-term mean for a third year, and the drought has driven crop failure and displacement across the Horn independently of any dam.

In July 2026, with the drought already established, Ethiopia began impounding the Beles storage scheme — not a hydropower project but a barrage and reservoir supplying a large irrigation command area in the western lowlands. It has no turbines and no downstream outlet in operation: water entering it is held and then applied to fields, and what reaches the Sudanese border from that sub-basin has fallen close to nothing. Ethiopia notified others of the project, but did not seek agreement, citing the CFA (Entebbe agreement, see glossary) and the right of the State that generates the water to use some of it. At Lake Nasser, in Egypt, water levels are lower through three dry years. It is near the level at which Egypt's hydroelectric production degrades. Egypt has imposed rationing, suspended rice cultivation, and stated that Ethiopia's permanent upstream reservoir abstraction, begun during a multi-year drought, is not a development project but a threat to Egypt's existence. Its military forces have mobilized.

Date	Development
October 2024	The Cooperative Framework Agreement, creating the Nile Basin Commission, enters into force on South Sudan's ratification. Egypt and Sudan reject it and refuse to join the new Commission.
9 September 2025	Ethiopia inaugurates the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam. Egypt raises the matter at the Security Council later that month; no action follows.
March 2026	Ethiopia announces three further Blue Nile hydropower projects. Cairo shifts from opposing construction to demanding a role in the operation — a dispute about scheduling, not water volume.
June–September 2026	A third consecutive below-average rainy season. Blue Nile flow far below mean; drought emergency declared across the Horn of Africa.
14 July 2026	Ethiopia begins impounding the Beles storage scheme — an irrigation reservoir with no downstream release in operation — with notification but without agreement.
Late September 2026	Lake Nasser approaches the level at which Aswan’s (a city in Egypt) hydroelectric generation degrades. Egypt imposes water rationing and suspends rice cultivation.
20 October 2026	Egypt recalls its ambassador, declares the filling of the reservoir an existential threat, and announces exercises in its southern military districts.
2 November 2026	Egyptian units redeploy southward; Egyptian reconnaissance overflights are reported. Ethiopia places air defences around the GERD and the Beles works at readiness.
12 November 2026	Freeze date. The contact group convenes in Nairobi at 09:00 EAT.

5. Freeze-Date Situation Report

The following conditions are assumed to exist at the opening gavel.

Hydrology: Blue Nile flow is in a third year well below the long-term mean. The Beles reservoir is filling and releasing nothing; the impoundment is reversible in principle, though the irrigation area it feeds is not, since the scheme exists to consume water every year from now on. Lake Nasser is near the threshold at which Aswan's electricity output degrades; below it, Egypt loses generating capacity as well as water. No party has agreed what constitutes a drought for operational purposes, so both are using their own definitions and both are technically correct.

Egypt: Rationing in force, rice cultivation suspended, agricultural unemployment rising in the Delta. Forces have moved south, and the government's public use of existential language has narrowed its own room to climb down. It has requested Security Council action and is canvassing support here.

Ethiopia: Impoundment continues. The government maintains the works are lawful under the CFA, that it has met its notification obligations, and that a State supplying most of the river may irrigate within it; it is simultaneously managing renewed instability in the north and a severe domestic drought of its own. It has signalled willingness to discuss an abstraction ceiling and a filling schedule, but not to suspend the scheme as a precondition, and not to accept that its share is zero.

Sudan and the region: Sudan is downstream of everything and governed by a State still at war with rogue states and warlords; its dams face both shortage and unannounced water release. Drought migratory displacement is climbing across the Horn, and alignments over the Sudanese war and Ethiopia's northern Tigray rebel crisis must be in the back of delegations minds during the committee.

Diplomatic: The 2015 Declaration of Principles remains signed and unimplemented. The Nile Basin Commission exists on paper with six members and no operating budget. Two prior mediations — the United States and the World Bank in 2019–2020, and the African Union in 2020–2021 — ended without agreement, and both are remembered here.

6. Core Issues Before the Contact Group

Issue	Questions for Delegates
Immediate de-escalation	What will make Egypt and Ethiopia stand down
Volume and release	Can the committee define a ceiling of impounded water, a guaranteed minimum release of water downstream from the Beles works, a drought trigger, and who measures all three? This is the achievable deliverable that delegates should think of solutions to.
Monitoring and verification	Whose satellites, whose gauges, whose staff will be on whose territory? Protocol must be established for foreign presence on supervising any agreement made during the committee.
The legal question	Affirm the 1929 and 1959 agreements, revise them, supersede them with the CFA, or deliberately leave them untouched? Whichever you pick binds every other state under the same instrument — not only the ones arguing today.
Everyone else's claims	Which other riparians hold entitlements under the instruments you are about to rule on, and are they all currently exercising them? A settlement that only balances Cairo against Addis Ababa has not counted the whole river.
Money	Who funds compensation, drought insurance, Egyptian irrigation efficiency and desalination? The Gulf and donor delegations can make cooperation profitable — on their terms.
Forum	Does this fall under the African Union process, Security Council file, or both? Nigeria and South Africa will resist Council seizure; Egypt wants it; China and Russia will not allow much there anyway.

7. Research Questions and Directive Architecture

- Has your country ratified the CFA, and what has it actually said about the 1929 and 1959 instruments? A delegation that misstates its own legal position will be corrected by the one sitting opposite. And what does your State hold that either party wants — money, weapons, port access, votes, recognition, a border? That, not your speech, is your influence here.
- Which of the two parties would your government genuinely prefer to see prevail, and can you say so out loud? Several delegations here cannot, and the gap between public and private position is where the crisis notes live.
- Which States in this basin hold an entitlement they are not currently drawing in full, and what happens to any settlement written here if one of them starts? Look the figures up rather than assuming.
- If the committee could deliver one paragraph that both capitals accepted, what would it say — and what would your delegation trade to get it?

What a strong instrument addresses

- A stated position on the 1929 and 1959 agreements and on the CFA — affirm, revise, supersede, or deliberately set aside. Apply it consistently: a rule binding one riparian binds every riparian holding a claim under the same text, including those not presently in dispute.
- Numbers. An abstraction ceiling, a guaranteed minimum release, a drought trigger, and a tolerance on each. A paragraph that says "equitable" without a figure has decided nothing and will be read by both capitals as a licence.
- Verification — whose gauges and satellites, sited where, reporting to whom, and what applies when two readings conflict?
- Material relief, not only legal assurance. Egypt's shortfall is physical: desalination, irrigation efficiency, conveyance-loss reduction and crop switching are water. A favourable legal finding is not.
- Financing and guarantors: who pays, who underwrites, over what period, and what the guarantee is worth if a party walks away.
- A defection clause. Decide now, in the calm, what this committee does if either party ignores the instrument — you will not get a better moment.

Directives — Directives are the form of resolution that passes during the crisis committee. They are essentially the same format but created in less time. That does not mean delegates should rush them.

Instruct the instruments listed under your Leverage, specifying what moves, who authorises it, and what is said to whom. A private approach to Cairo or Addis Ababa, carried by a delegation that the party actually trusts, is among the most effective moves available. Joint directives require every contributing delegation's sponsorship — a financing package assembled by the Gulf, donor and Council delegations together is the most powerful object this committee can build.

The final instrument — may be a framework agreement, a technical protocol, a monitoring mandate, a standstill declaration, or a financing compact. Choose the form to fit what the parties can accept, not what reads most impressively. A release-and-abstraction protocol that both capitals accept is worth more than a comprehensive treaty that neither does.

8. Terms Delegates Should Know

GERD — Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam, on the Blue Nile; inaugurated 9 September 2025, roughly 5,150 MW installed.	**Beles storage scheme** — Fictional. A Blue Nile barrage and reservoir supplying an irrigation command area; it impounds water and releases none downstream.

CFA (Entebbe Agreement) — Cooperative Framework Agreement; in force October 2024, ratified by six upstream States; creates the Nile Basin Commission.	**1929 and 1959 agreements —** Colonial-era and bilateral instruments giving Egypt upstream veto rights and splitting measured flow: 55.5 bcm Egypt, 18.5 bcm Sudan.
Equitable and reasonable utilisation — The customary principle that basin States share a river fairly, weighed against historic-rights claims.	**No significant harm —** The companion principle: a State may not seriously damage co-riparians. Each party invokes a different one of the pair.
Declaration of Principles (2015) — Signed by all three parties; committed them to agree filling and operating rules. Never implemented; talks collapsed December 2023.	**Lake Nasser —** Egypt's reservoir behind the Aswan High Hydroelectric Dam; the downstream buffer that a multi-year drought draws down.
Consumptive use — Water taken and not returned — crops transpire it, reservoirs evaporate it. The loss recurs annually, unlike a one-off filling.	**bcm —** Billion cubic metres, the unit of Nile allocation. Measured flow at Aswan is conventionally about 84 bcm.
Kiremt — The Ethiopian highland rainy season, June to September, which generates the Blue Nile flood.	**Command area —** The land a scheme irrigates. Its size, not the reservoir's, determines how much water is consumed each year.

9. Sources — Nile Basin Initiative material on the CFA; International Water Law Project and EJIL:Talk!; Al Jazeera on the GERD inauguration and the March 2026 projects; FPRI on the GERD dispute; IWA Publishing on the 1959 agreement; the Egyptian State Information Service for Cairo's position; Chatham House and the Soufan Center on Ethiopia–Eritrea. Figures vary between sources — cite yours rather than asserting a number.

10. Country Position Sheet

Read your own entry closely and skim the rest to find your bloc. These are starting points, not the whole of any government's position — verify and extend them from your foreign ministry's own statements and from your country's actual record on the Cooperative Framework Agreement. Leverage lists what you may direct by private directive; anything beyond it must be requested from the delegation that holds it.

Sudan *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: The only State that sits directly between the two parties and the one physically closest to the dams. Sudan holds 18.5 billion cubic metres under the 1959 agreement, operates the Roseires and Sennar dams immediately downstream of the GERD, and has been fractured by civil war since 2023, so it arrives with a contested government and a genuinely divided national interest.

Strategic Interests: Secure predictable water and sediment flows for its own irrigation and dams; avoid becoming the battlefield or transit corridor of an Egypt–Ethiopia confrontation; extract reconstruction financing; keep its claim under the 1959 agreement alive without alienating upstream neighbours.

Likely Priorities: A binding data-sharing and release-notification protocol above all else — Sudan is the State that drowns or dries with no warning; drought-season minimum flows; recognition that regulated flow benefits Sudanese agriculture; humanitarian and reconstruction aid detached from the water question.

Leverage: Physical position between the parties, control of the Roseires reservoir, the Egyptian relationship, and the ability to legitimise or wreck any technical monitoring arrangement placed on its territory.

Red Lines: Any arrangement negotiated over Sudan's head between Cairo and Addis Ababa; foreign military movement across Sudanese territory; language treating the 1959 allocations as void.

Likely Allies: Egypt historically and on legal claims; South Sudan and Eritrea on regional questions; Saudi Arabia and Qatar on financing.

South Sudan *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: The world's youngest State and the sixth ratifier of the Cooperative Framework Agreement, whose July 2024 instrument brought the treaty into force in October 2024. It sits on the White Nile, depends on pipelines through Sudan for its oil revenue, and has little institutional capacity to spare for a dispute it did not create.

Strategic Interests: Keep oil flowing through Sudanese infrastructure; attract development financing for its own water and power needs; avoid being forced to choose publicly between Cairo and Addis Ababa; establish itself as a serious actor in basin institutions.

Likely Priorities: Stand up the Nile Basin Commission the CFA created; development financing for the Sudd region and hydropower; a basin-wide framing rather than a three-State dispute; humanitarian support for populations displaced by drought.

Leverage: The vote that brought the CFA into force, White Nile position, and standing as a State with no historical stake in the colonial treaties.

Red Lines: Being pressured to renounce CFA ratification; conditionality tying water cooperation to its internal politics; any measure that disrupts oil transit.

Likely Allies: Uganda, Kenya, Tanzania, Rwanda and Burundi as CFA ratifiers; Sudan on transit.

Uganda *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: Source of the White Nile at Lake Victoria, a CFA ratifier since 2019, and for two decades one of the loudest critics of the colonial-era allocations. Uganda has its own hydropower programme and reads Egyptian claims of historic rights as an attempt to freeze upstream development permanently.

Strategic Interests: Defend the principle of equitable and reasonable utilisation; protect its own dam-building future from any precedent set here; keep Lake Victoria governance out of the dispute; position itself as a regional power broker.

Likely Priorities: A basin-wide legal framework rather than a bilateral fix; operationalising the Nile Basin Commission; refusal of any text that recognises prior-use rights; financing for East African power interconnection.

Leverage: Control of White Nile outflow at Jinja, CFA standing, and a substantial regional military with peacekeeping deployments.

Red Lines: Any recognition of the 1929 or 1959 agreements as binding on upstream States; external arbitration imposed on basin members; Lake Victoria being brought into the bargaining.

Likely Allies: Tanzania, Rwanda, Burundi, South Sudan, Kenya — the CFA bloc, which Uganda effectively leads.

Kenya *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: Host of this summit and the region's diplomatic and commercial hub. Kenya is a CFA ratifier with a comparatively small direct stake in Nile flow, which is exactly what makes it a credible convenor — it has more to gain from the region not going to war than from any particular allocation.

Strategic Interests: Protect regional trade and investor confidence; establish Nairobi as the venue where African crises are resolved; keep the East African Community intact across the dispute; avoid a refugee and food-price shock.

Likely Priorities: A ceasefire-equivalent standstill on military movement; a credible monitoring and verification mechanism; sequencing that gets a technical agreement before a political one; keeping channels open to both capitals so neither stops answering.

Leverage: Convening power and the chair's procedural authority, regional transport and financial infrastructure, and working relationships with every delegation in the room.

Red Lines: The summit collapsing into a blocs shouting match on its territory; unilateral external military deployment into the Horn; being asked to take a side on the legal question.

Likely Allies: The CFA bloc on law; Nigeria, South Africa and Norway on mediation; the donor States on financing.

Tanzania *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: A CFA ratifier since 2015 with Lake Victoria frontage and a long-standing doctrinal objection to inherited colonial obligations — the Nyerere doctrine on treaty succession originated here. Tanzania is cautious, legalistic and unusually consistent.

Strategic Interests: Keep the principle of sovereign equality intact; protect Lake Victoria and its own water projects; avoid entanglement in Horn of Africa security disputes; maintain non-alignment between Gulf and Western blocs.

Likely Priorities: Basin-wide institutions over bilateral deals; a technical rather than a security framing; explicit language that the CFA governs; development financing with no political conditions.

Leverage: Lake Victoria position, CFA standing, and considerable moral authority on the treaty-succession question.

Red Lines: Any Security Council framing that makes the Nile a threat-to-peace file; recognition of prior-use rights; militarisation of a water dispute.

Likely Allies: Uganda, Rwanda, Burundi, South Sudan, Kenya.

Rwanda *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: An early CFA ratifier sitting on the Nile's furthest headwaters, with a foreign policy built on sovereign equality and a reputation for saying plainly what larger States imply. Its position is complicated by its relationship with the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which sits in this room.

Strategic Interests: Defend upstream rights absolutely; avoid the precedent that a downstream State can veto upstream development; maintain donor relationships; keep regional attention away from its own disputes.

Likely Priorities: The CFA as the governing instrument; rejection of any prior-notification obligation that amounts to a veto; regional power trading; a technical commission with real authority.

Leverage: Headwaters position, a capable and deployable military, and disproportionate diplomatic influence for its size.

Red Lines: Any veto-equivalent notification requirement; linkage of the Nile question to its regional disputes; reopening of the CFA text.

Likely Allies: Uganda, Tanzania, Burundi; tense with the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Burundi *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: The CFA's fifth ratifier in 2023 and the smallest riparian in the room, sitting on headwater tributaries with almost no capacity to influence flows and acute need for electricity and investment.

Strategic Interests: Convert participation into development financing; avoid being ignored in a dispute between much larger States; secure regional power supply; maintain the CFA bloc's cohesion.

Likely Priorities: Hydropower and irrigation financing; a guaranteed voice for small riparians in any new commission; technical assistance; no obligations it cannot implement.

Leverage: A vote in the CFA bloc and headwater position; little else, which it will say openly.

Red Lines: Decisions taken by the large States and presented to small ones; financing tied to alignment; being excluded from the commission's governance.

Likely Allies: Rwanda, Tanzania, Uganda, South Sudan.

Democratic Republic of the Congo *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: A Nile riparian through Lake Albert with a marginal stake in Nile flow and extraordinary water wealth elsewhere — the Congo basin and the Inga hydropower potential dwarf anything under discussion. It has not ratified the CFA and arrives with its own regional preoccupations.

Strategic Interests: Attract financing to Congolese hydropower rather than Nile projects; use the summit to raise its regional security concerns; avoid committing to a framework that constrains it later; balance between blocs.

Likely Priorities: Continental power-trading infrastructure; a wide framing that includes African energy development generally; non-binding language on basin obligations; regional security discussion alongside water.

Leverage: Continental-scale hydropower potential, African Union standing, and a swing position between the CFA bloc and the unaligned.

Red Lines: Being bound by a framework it has not ratified; Rwandan framing of regional security questions; obligations without financing.

Likely Allies: Situational; closer to Nigeria and South Africa than to the CFA bloc.

Eritrea *Nile Basin riparian*

Profile: A Nile Basin State through the Tekezé–Atbara system, outside the Nile Basin Initiative, and currently the most hostile of Ethiopia's neighbours. Relations with Addis Ababa have deteriorated sharply over Red Sea access claims, and Eritrean involvement in the renewed Tigray crisis has been reported through 2026.

Strategic Interests: Constrain Ethiopian power by any available means; defeat Ethiopian claims to sea access absolutely; deepen alignment with Cairo; avoid international scrutiny of its own conduct.

Likely Priorities: The hardest available language on unilateral dam operation; linkage between the water dispute and Ethiopian regional conduct; rejection of any measure that strengthens Ethiopia's position; no monitoring mission near its territory.

Leverage: Position on Ethiopia's northern flank, control of Red Sea coastline Ethiopia wants access to, and the capacity to raise Ethiopia's costs elsewhere.

Red Lines: Any text acknowledging Ethiopian sea-access claims; international monitoring on Eritrean soil; being asked to normalise with Addis Ababa as part of a package.

Likely Allies: Egypt closely; Somalia and Saudi Arabia on Ethiopian containment.

Nigeria *African Union State*

Profile: Africa's largest economy and population, with no stake whatsoever in Nile flow and a strong interest in how this precedent lands. Nigeria shares the Niger and Lake Chad basins with neighbours and watches carefully what the room decides about upstream and downstream rights.

Strategic Interests: Keep the dispute inside African institutions; prevent a precedent that downstream States may veto upstream development, or that upstream States owe nothing; maintain its claim to continental leadership; avoid Gulf and Western powers dictating an African outcome.

Likely Priorities: African Union primacy over Security Council involvement; a mediation panel of African eminent persons; general principles applicable across African basins; funding channelled through African institutions.

Leverage: Continental weight, ECOWAS standing, peacekeeping capacity, and credibility as a genuinely disinterested party.

Red Lines: Security Council seizure of the file; a precedent usable against Nigeria in the Niger or Chad basins; external military deployment to the Horn.

Likely Allies: South Africa, Kenya, the African Union bloc generally.

South Africa *African Union State*

Profile: The continent's most experienced mediator, with a functioning transboundary water arrangement of its own in the Lesotho Highlands and a diplomatic tradition built on negotiated settlement. It has no Nile stake and considerable interest in being the one who fixes this.

Strategic Interests: Demonstrate African capacity to resolve African disputes; prevent great-power competition from colonising the file; protect the principle of negotiated transboundary arrangements; maintain non-aligned credibility.

Likely Priorities: A structured mediation process with a named panel and a timetable; technical confidence-building before political negotiation; the Lesotho Highlands treaty as a working model; no coercive measures.

Leverage: Mediation credibility, legal and technical expertise on transboundary water, and BRICS standing that gives it access to both Moscow and Beijing.

Red Lines: Sanctions or coercive measures against any party; Security Council primacy; a settlement imposed by external powers.

Likely Allies: Nigeria, Kenya, Norway; heard respectfully by all blocs.

Somalia *African Union State*

Profile: Aligned with Cairo since the 2024 Ethiopia–Somaliland port memorandum, and host to Egyptian troops deployed under African Union arrangements. Somalia's own water crisis is severe and entirely separate from the Nile, which it will point out when convenient.

Strategic Interests: Maintain Egyptian support against Ethiopian regional ambitions; resist any recognition of Somaliland arrangements; secure drought and humanitarian assistance; keep Ethiopian influence in its territory limited.

Likely Priorities: Language on territorial integrity and unilateral action that reads across to its own dispute; humanitarian financing for the drought; Egyptian and Gulf backing; an African Union framing it can shape.

Leverage: Its vote, its position on Ethiopia's eastern flank, and its ability to escalate a parallel dispute if ignored.

Red Lines: Any recognition of Somaliland; Ethiopian sea access through Somali territory; being treated as an Egyptian proxy in public.

Likely Allies: Egypt above all; Eritrea, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Turkey.

Djibouti *African Union State*

Profile: The most exposed small State in the region. Roughly the whole of Ethiopian import and export traffic moves through Djiboutian ports, giving it enormous leverage it dare not use, and it hosts foreign military bases from several of the powers seated in this room.

Strategic Interests: Keep Ethiopian trade flowing — it is the national economy; avoid any confrontation that closes the corridor; maintain balance between the foreign powers based on its soil; prevent Ethiopia from obtaining an alternative port.

Likely Priorities: De-escalation above all outcomes; protection of the corridor and port infrastructure; quiet mediation rather than public positioning; reassurance to every base-hosting power at once.

Leverage: Ethiopia's trade lifeline, hosting arrangements with multiple major powers, and a credible claim to be the State with the most to lose from any escalation.

Red Lines: Being asked to interdict Ethiopian trade; military action originating from its territory; any arrangement giving Ethiopia a rival corridor.

Likely Allies: Pragmatically everyone; closest working ties with France, the United States and China.

Saudi Arabia *Gulf and Near East*

Profile: A Red Sea littoral power with deep financial ties to Egypt, agricultural investments across Sudan and the Horn, and an interest in the Nile basin as part of its own food security. Riyadh has leaned toward Cairo and, per reporting through 2026, toward actors opposing Addis Ababa.

Strategic Interests: Preserve Egyptian stability, which it has repeatedly underwritten; secure Red Sea shipping and its own agricultural holdings; limit Emirati influence in the Horn; avoid a refugee and food-price shock reaching the Gulf.

Likely Priorities: Large-scale financing tied to a settlement it helps shape; Red Sea security discussed alongside water; support for Egyptian positions short of endorsing force; a Gulf role in any monitoring or compensation fund.

Leverage: Financing at a scale no African State can match, energy supply relationships, and influence over Egyptian economic stability.

Red Lines: An outcome that materially weakens Egypt; Emirati primacy in the settlement; Iranian or hostile presence near the Red Sea approaches.

Likely Allies: Egypt, Eritrea, Somalia; competitive with the United Arab Emirates; aligned with the United States.

United Arab Emirates *Gulf and Near East*

Profile: The Gulf State most invested in Ethiopia, with substantial financing, port and agricultural interests across the Horn, and a position in the Sudanese war opposite Saudi Arabia's. It has more to lose from Ethiopian isolation than any other delegation here.

Strategic Interests: Protect Ethiopian investments and the Ethiopian growth story; expand Red Sea port and logistics holdings; outmanoeuvre Saudi influence; keep the dispute commercial rather than military.

Likely Priorities: Financing packages that make cooperation more attractive than confrontation; irrigation-efficiency investment in Egypt paid for as the price of Ethiopian abstraction; opposition to sanctions; a compensation mechanism rather than a legal ruling.

Leverage: Capital, port and logistics networks across the Horn, and the closest commercial relationship with Addis Ababa of anyone in the room.

Red Lines: Sanctions or measures targeting Ethiopian projects; Saudi-led framing; any settlement that devalues its Horn investments.

Likely Allies: Ethiopia in effect; competitive with Saudi Arabia and Qatar; aligned with the United States commercially.

Qatar *Gulf and Near East*

Profile: A State whose foreign policy is built on being the venue and guarantor for other people's agreements, with a track record of mediation across Africa and the Middle East and enough money to make a settlement attractive.

Strategic Interests: Secure the mediation role and the prestige that follows; balance Saudi and Emirati influence; maintain relationships with both Cairo and Addis Ababa; convert diplomatic success into standing.

Likely Priorities: An offer to host and underwrite negotiations; a compensation or drought-insurance fund it would substantially finance; confidence-building measures; no coercive language that would foreclose its role.

Leverage: Sovereign wealth, a mediation record both parties accept, and open channels to actors others cannot reach.

Red Lines: Being excluded from the mediation architecture; Saudi or Emirati monopoly over the financing; a settlement that requires it to choose a side.

Likely Allies: Turkey closely; acceptable to nearly everyone, which is the point.

Turkey *Gulf and Near East*

Profile: A growing military and commercial presence across the Horn, with a base in Somalia, defence exports to several States here, and — uncomfortably — its own record as an upstream dam-builder on the Tigris and Euphrates that downstream neighbours have objected to for decades.

Strategic Interests: Expand influence in the Horn and East Africa; protect defence and construction contracts; avoid any precedent constraining upstream dam-builders, which would read directly onto its own projects; balance against Gulf rivals.

Likely Priorities: Strong language on upstream sovereign rights paired with voluntary cooperation; technical and construction involvement in any agreed works; mediation alongside Qatar; nothing that creates binding prior-consent obligations.

Leverage: Defence exports and drones supplied across the region, construction capacity, the Somali base, and NATO membership.

Red Lines: Any precedent requiring upstream States to obtain downstream consent; exclusion from Horn security arrangements; European framing of the legal question.

Likely Allies: Qatar, Somalia; transactional with Ethiopia and with Egypt simultaneously.

United States *Permanent Member of the Security Council*

Profile: Attempted to broker this dispute once before, in 2019–2020, in a Treasury-led process that Ethiopia walked away from and that damaged Washington's standing as an honest broker. It returns with leverage, history, and limited appetite for another failure.

Strategic Interests: Prevent war between two partners; protect Red Sea and Suez shipping; limit Chinese and Russian gains from a prolonged crisis; avoid an open-ended commitment in the Horn.

Likely Priorities: A technical agreement on drought-period operation as the achievable win; financing levers through the international financial institutions; deterrence of military action by either party; African Union front-of-house with American underwriting behind it.

Leverage: Influence over IMF and World Bank programmes on which several delegations depend, intelligence and satellite monitoring capability, and security relationships with both parties.

Red Lines: Military action by either party; Russian or Chinese security roles in the settlement; an outcome that closes Red Sea shipping.

Likely Allies: United Kingdom, France, Germany, Saudi Arabia; working relations with the African Union bloc.

China *Permanent Member of the Security Council*

Profile: The largest financier and builder of infrastructure across the basin, with turbines, transmission lines and loans in several of the States represented here, and a doctrinal commitment to non-interference that it will invoke early and often.

Strategic Interests: Protect infrastructure investments and loan exposure on both sides; keep the dispute out of the Security Council where it would have to take a position; expand power-trading and transmission projects; avoid precedent for international scrutiny of dam projects.

Likely Priorities: Technical cooperation and financing rather than legal adjudication; regional power interconnection as the commercial solution; opposition to sanctions; African ownership of the process, which conveniently keeps outsiders from setting rules.

Leverage: Construction and financing capacity across the basin, existing contracts with nearly every delegation, and a Security Council veto.

Red Lines: Security Council coercive measures; an international review mechanism for dam projects; framing that treats Chinese-built infrastructure as a security problem.

Likely Allies: Formally non-aligned; overlaps with the African Union bloc on process and with Russia on Council questions.

Russian Federation *Permanent Member of the Security Council*

Profile: Egypt's principal arms supplier and the builder of its nuclear power plant at El Dabaa, with expanding security relationships across the Horn and an interest in Red Sea access. It benefits from Western failure here more than from any particular water outcome.

Strategic Interests: Deepen the Egyptian relationship; expand Red Sea and Horn footholds; demonstrate that Western mediation fails and Russian mediation does not; protect nuclear and arms contracts.

Likely Priorities: Sympathy for Egyptian security concerns without committing to anything; an offer of Russian mediation or technical involvement; opposition to Western-led mechanisms; no Security Council action that sets precedent.

Leverage: Security Council veto, arms supply relationships, nuclear construction contracts, and security partnerships across the region.

Red Lines: Western-led enforcement mechanisms; any measure affecting the El Dabaa project; NATO-adjacent deployments in the Red Sea.

Likely Allies: Egypt; tactical alignment with China on Council process; courts Eritrea and Sudan.

France *Permanent Member of the Security Council*

Profile: A Security Council member with a base in Djibouti, significant commercial and nuclear-sector interests in Egypt, and an established role in European water diplomacy. France reads the crisis through Red Sea security and through the precedent it sets for shared-basin law.

Strategic Interests: Protect Red Sea and Suez traffic; maintain influence in the Horn through Djibouti; support international water law as a European strength; keep European States relevant to an African settlement.

Likely Priorities: Codified drought-operation rules grounded in the 1997 Watercourses Convention framework; European technical and financing contributions; Security Council engagement short of coercion; a monitoring mechanism with real instruments.

Leverage: Council seat, the Djibouti base, technical hydrological expertise, and EU financing influence.

Red Lines: Unilateral military action; exclusion of European States from the settlement architecture; a purely bilateral outcome with no legal content.

Likely Allies: United Kingdom, Germany, Italy, United States, Norway.

United Kingdom *Permanent Member of the Security Council*

Profile: The author, as colonial power, of the 1929 agreement that gave Egypt its veto over upstream works — a fact every CFA ratifier in this room will raise, probably in the first session. London has since become a significant aid donor and a centre of international water-law expertise.

Strategic Interests: Manage the historical liability without conceding that the treaties are void; protect shipping and commercial interests; maintain influence through technical and legal contribution; prevent Council paralysis.

Likely Priorities: A forward-looking framework that supersedes rather than adjudicates the colonial instruments; legal and hydrological expertise offered to the process; humanitarian financing for the drought; a monitoring and early-warning mechanism.

Leverage: Council seat, development financing, legal expertise, and long-standing relationships across the basin.

Red Lines: A formal finding that the 1929 or 1959 agreements were unlawful; open-ended liability arguments; military escalation.

Likely Allies: United States, France, Germany, Norway, Kenya.

Italy *Donor and technical partner*

Profile: The State whose engineering firm built the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam, and a former colonial power in the Horn with a long and complicated history in both Ethiopia and Eritrea. Italy also faces the migration consequences of any Horn destabilisation more directly than any other European State.

Strategic Interests: Protect its construction and engineering contracts across Ethiopian water infrastructure; prevent a Horn crisis that drives migration toward the Central Mediterranean; maintain its Mattei Plan credibility in Africa.

Likely Priorities: Technical solutions and engineering contributions; financing for drought resilience and irrigation efficiency in Egypt; opposition to measures that would halt construction outright; a commercial rather than a punitive framing.

Leverage: The engineering relationship with Ethiopia that nobody else has, European financing instruments, and Mediterranean migration diplomacy.

Red Lines: Measures that freeze or sanction Ethiopian water projects wholesale; a Horn collapse producing mass movement north; exclusion from the technical architecture.

Likely Allies: Germany, France, Norway; a working channel to Ethiopia most European States lack.

Germany *Donor and technical partner*

Profile: One of the largest bilateral donors to both Egypt and Ethiopia and a long-standing funder of Nile Basin Initiative institutions. Germany's influence here is entirely financial and technical, which it regards as the only influence that will still matter in five years.

Strategic Interests: Protect a decade of investment in basin institutions; prevent a conflict that destroys the development portfolio; support rules-based transboundary governance as a matter of principle; avoid a migration and food-security shock.

Likely Priorities: Funding the Nile Basin Commission into actual operation; drought early-warning and data infrastructure; irrigation efficiency programmes in Egypt, which uses roughly 85 per cent of its water on agriculture; conditionality attached to cooperation rather than to politics.

Leverage: Substantial development financing, technical hydrological institutions, and EU budgetary influence.

Red Lines: Financing used as a weapon against either party; abandonment of the basin institutions it has funded; military escalation.

Likely Allies: Norway, France, United Kingdom, Italy; trusted by the African Union bloc.

Norway *Donor and technical partner*

Profile: A long-standing funder of the Nile Basin Initiative and a State whose entire diplomatic brand rests on quiet, technically competent mediation in disputes where it has no interests of its own. It is the delegation most likely to be trusted by everyone and least likely to be listened to by the large powers.

Strategic Interests: Keep basin institutions alive; demonstrate the value of impartial mediation; protect a development portfolio built over two decades; advance international water law generally.

Likely Priorities: A technical process insulated from the political dispute; funding for joint monitoring and a shared hydrological database; a drought protocol as the single achievable deliverable; facilitation offered without conditions.

Leverage: Trusted-mediator standing, sustained financing for basin institutions, and hydropower expertise that is genuinely world-class.

Red Lines: Politicisation of the technical institutions it funds; coercive measures; being used as cover for another State's agenda.

Likely Allies: Germany, South Africa, Kenya, Qatar on mediation; respected by the CFA bloc.